OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Questions to Mayor White and CEO Constance on threats, safety and engagement

Sent 20 October 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 10 November 2026

OPEN LETTER

To: Cr Patricia White, Mayor, and Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council
From: Stephen Prothero, Eye on Shoalhaven Council
Date: 20 October 2026
Subject: Political violence, threats and engagement: questions arising from the attack on Helen Haines MP

STATUS OF THIS LETTER
This is a public open letter to the Chief Executive Officer. It is published by Eye on Shoalhaven Council as a matter of public interest journalism.

It is not a complaint. It is not a complaint under Council's Complaint Handling Policy, and it is not to be registered, assessed or managed as one.
It is not a Code of Conduct complaint. It does not allege a breach of the Code of Conduct by any person, and it is not to be referred to the Complaints Coordinator, a conduct reviewer or the Office of Local Government.
It is not an access application. It is not an application under the Government Information (Public Access) Act 2009 (NSW), formal or informal, and no statutory time limit is started by it.
It is not a request for service. It does not ask Council to take action, to make a decision, or to review a decision.
It is a set of questions put to a public official in the same way a journalist puts questions to the head of an organisation. The Chief Executive may answer all, some or none of the questions, and may do so in whatever form and at whatever time he chooses. Some questions can be answered in a line and others may need work. If the Chief Executive intends to comment on any question, a short reply to this email saying so is all that is needed.

Replies will be published in full. If no reply is received, that will be recorded as it stands.

Background
On Monday 19 October 2026, independent MP Helen Haines was critically injured when she was struck by a vehicle outside her electorate office in Wangaratta. The Prime Minister has described it as a deliberate act, and police are still establishing the motive. A man has been arrested, and the allegations are untested. Leaders across the political divide have condemned the attack, and ASIO's Director-General has linked inflamed language with a

more permissive environment for violence. I have written about this in an opinion article published today.

In that article I disclosed that I have received a direct threat from a supporter of a sitting councillor, and that police became involved. I had written to the CEO on this issue. To my knowledge the councillor concerned has not addressed it publicly.

Questions
Because the temperature of public debate affects councils as much as parliaments, I put the following questions.

1. Mayor: does the Mayor condemn the attack on Helen Haines, and will she state publicly that threats or intimidation of anyone engaged in local government, including councillors, staff, residents and journalists, are unacceptable?

1. Mayor: does the Mayor consider that a councillor should publicly address a threat made by a person who identifies as that councillor's supporter, and if so, what does she say about the matter I have described?

1. CEO: what policies and procedures does Council currently have for responding to threats or abuse directed at councillors, staff and members of the public in connection with Council business, and when were they last reviewed?

1. CEO: has Council assessed the safety of councillors, staff and the public at meetings and in contact with Council since the events of this week, and what was the outcome?

1. CEO: how many requests from residents for information, correspondence or meetings with councillors or senior staff were received in the last 12 months, and how many received a substantive reply within Council's own stated timeframes?

1. CEO: what does Council say to residents who believe that the open meeting, public address and information access arrangements are used to limit rather than encourage engagement?

1. Both: what practical steps will each of you take, in your own role, to lower the temperature in the Shoalhaven by engaging openly with critics and the community?

Publication
This letter and any reply will be published by Eye on Shoalhaven Council in full.

Yours faithfully,

Stephen Prothero
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